

21 World War II

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J. Howard Miller

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WAR PRODUCTION CO-ORDINATING COMMITTEE

HISTORY

Australia — ready for war?

Student: Class: Due date:

As soon as Britain was at war, Australia was also at war, despite the fact that, in many ways, Australia was not war ready.

The AIF had been disbanded after the Great War and Citizen Military Forces (land forces) had been established to defend Australia. Its numbers had increased from 35 000 in mid 1938 to 80 000 plus in mid 1939, but these men served part-time and were poorly equipped. The RAAF had only been formed in 1920. The RAN was better equipped than land or air forces, though it had fewer serviceable ships than in 1918.

1. On the attack

a. Describe Australia's readiness to engage in war overseas in September 1939.

The Navy was probably the most prepared to engage in overseas conflict because it had been equipped to support the British Navy. Many of Australia's land forces would have been inexperienced and only trained to defend home soil, not to engage overseas. The RAAF was only formed after World War I, so it was relatively new and not as experienced as the RAN.

b. At the outbreak of war, were Australians who were not already in the forces willing to enlist? Explain.

Many Australians still believed it was their duty to support Britain, so some would have enlisted for this reason. However, Australians now knew the horrors of war and therefore were not as eager to enlist as earlier generations.

c. Why did enlistments increase in mid 1940? Refer to the timeline over the page.

Between April and June, Germany overran six countries, including France — Australia's ally in the Great War. Australians now realised how dangerous Germany was.

d. Why can the division sent to Malaya in 1939 be termed 'forward defence'?

There were fears that Japan, Germany's ally, would enter the war. Troops in Malaya were in a 'forward' position, supporting the British base in Singapore and could help stop the Japanese ever reaching Australia.

e. Despite their lack of preparedness, do you think Australians fought effectively in overseas campaigns? Why or why not?

Despite a defeat in Greece, overall the Australians proved themselves to be tough and effective, especially in North Africa and the Middle East.

2. On the defensive

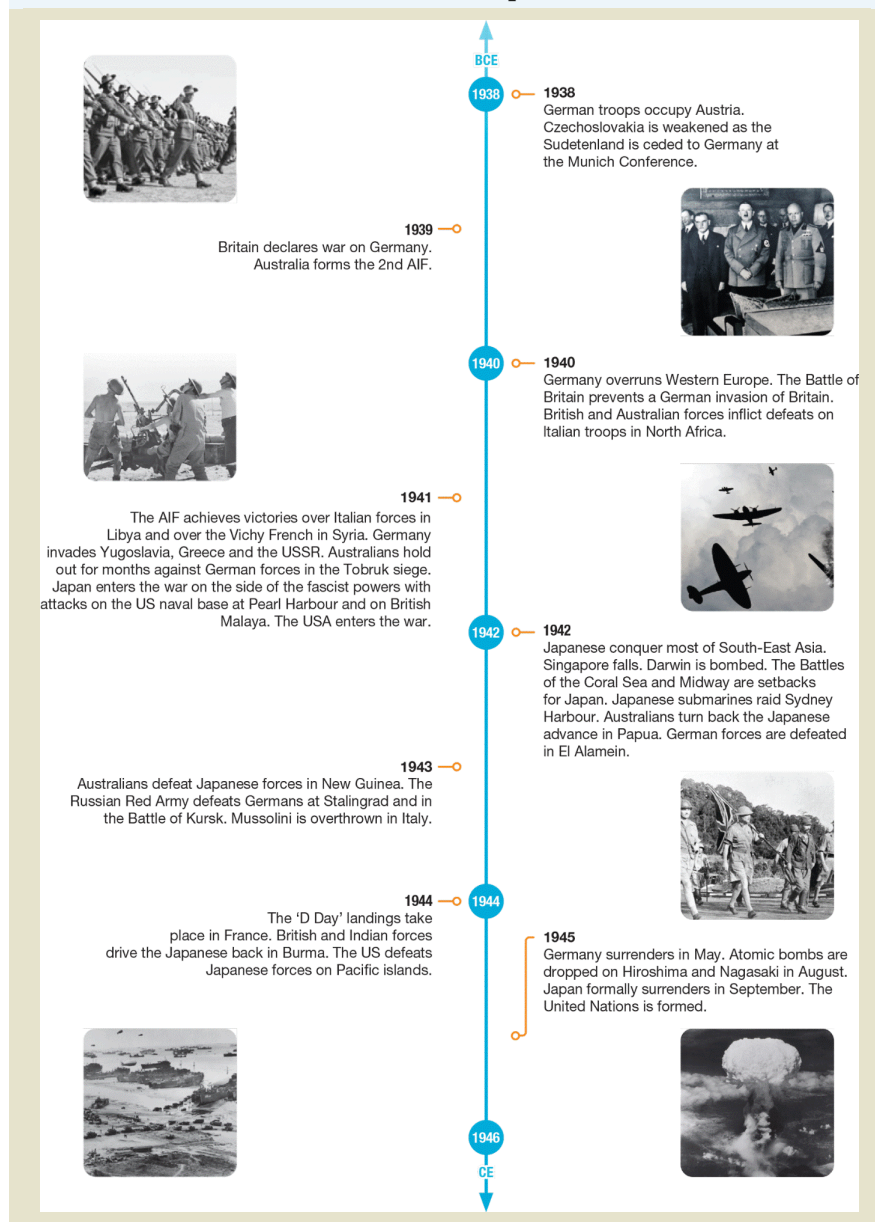
a. Prior to World War II, in what ways do you think Australia was vulnerable to foreign aggression?

With its huge coastline and vast land mass, Australia had a huge area to defend and few people to defend it. Its defence force was generally small and ill-equipped. Its major ally, Britain, was a long way away.

b. Australia's prime minister, John Curtin, refused Churchill's request for Australian troops in Burma. Why? Why was this refusal a brave act?

Curtin believed Australia needed as many troops at home as possible to stop the Japanese advance into the Pacific, especially after the fall of Singapore. It was a brave act, because it was saying 'no' to Australia's greatest ally.

A timeline of the course and consequences of World War II



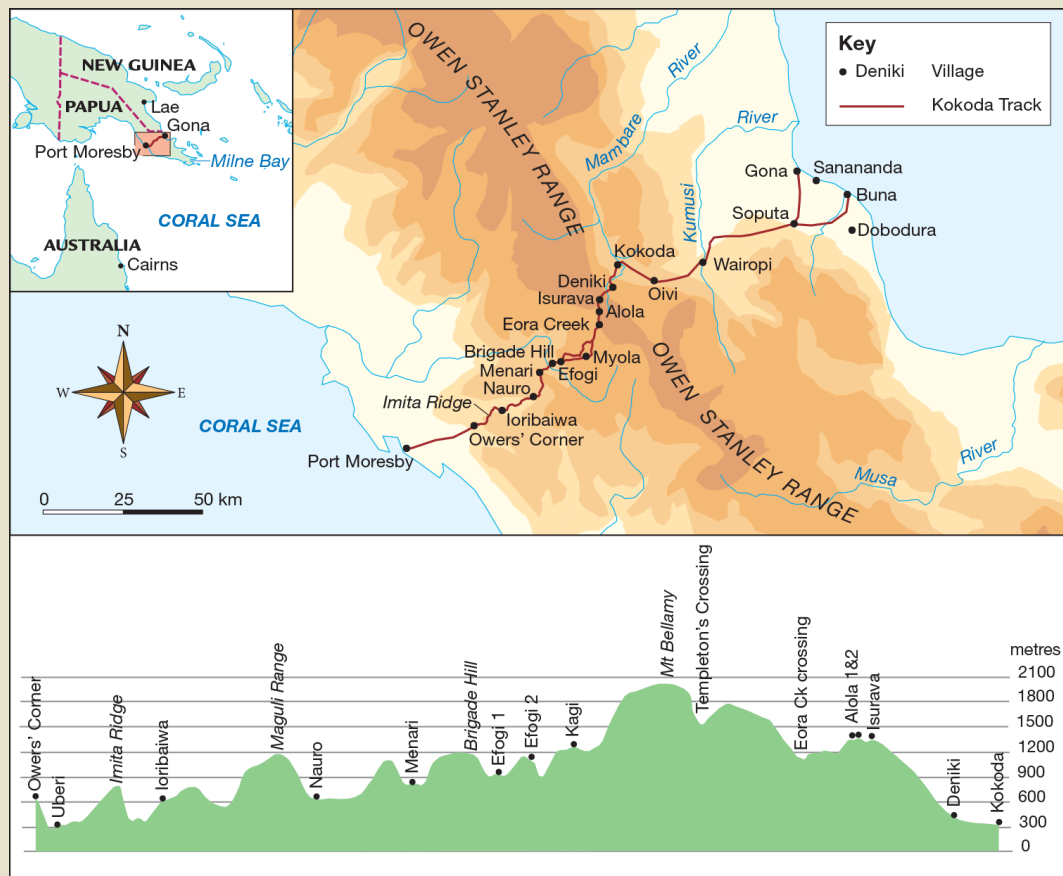
HISTORY

Australians in the Pacific War

Student: Class: Due date:

Kokoda: In 1942, a Japanese force was sent to take Port Moresby, Papua, which lies only about 500 km north-east of the Australian coastline and only 850 km from Cairns, Queensland.

SOURCE 1 Map and cross-section of the Kokoda Track



1. Study SOURCE 1 above.

- a. Why would it have been easier for the Japanese to approach Kokoda from the north than for the Australians and Papuans to approach from the south?

The Japanese would have been travelling on a better and wider surface — a road, not a track.

The Japanese also approached via a river valley, whereas the Australians and Papuans had to climb and cross the mountains.

- b. The Australians were forced back as far as Imita Ridge. What defensive advantage might this village have provided for them?

The name suggests the village was situated on a ridge, so the Australians would have had the advantage of looking down on approaching enemies.

2. The Australians and Papuans were disadvantaged in other ways. Add a brief explanation about each of the following:

- a. Communication: Australians and Papuans would have had problems due to a language barrier.
- b. Size of force: They were outnumbered.
- c. Training and resource: The Australian troops were militia troops, not AIF; they were young and less well trained and equipped.

3. How did fighting alongside the Papuans give the Australians an advantage?

The Papuans would have known the terrain well, as well as the vegetation, wildlife and weather.

4. In the end, what brought success for the Australians to this campaign?

The Japanese ran out of supplies and had to retreat.

Beyond Kokoda: In 1939, the island of New Guinea was split in three: to the west was Dutch New Guinea, but Australians fought in New Guinea (the north-east controlled by Australia under a League of Nations mandate) and in Papua (an Australian colony in the south-east). The Bismarck Sea lay north of New Guinea and Milne Bay at the south-east tip of Papua.

5. Why do you think Australians would have fought determinedly in the campaigns in New Guinea and Papua?

Due to Australia's size and sparse population, our forces would have had little hope of repelling Japanese troops if they had landed on Australian soil, so they were determined to keep this from happening. Also, Australia had a responsibility to protect the people and land of New Guinea and Papua.

6. Why were some other Pacific campaigns considered wasteful by Australia?

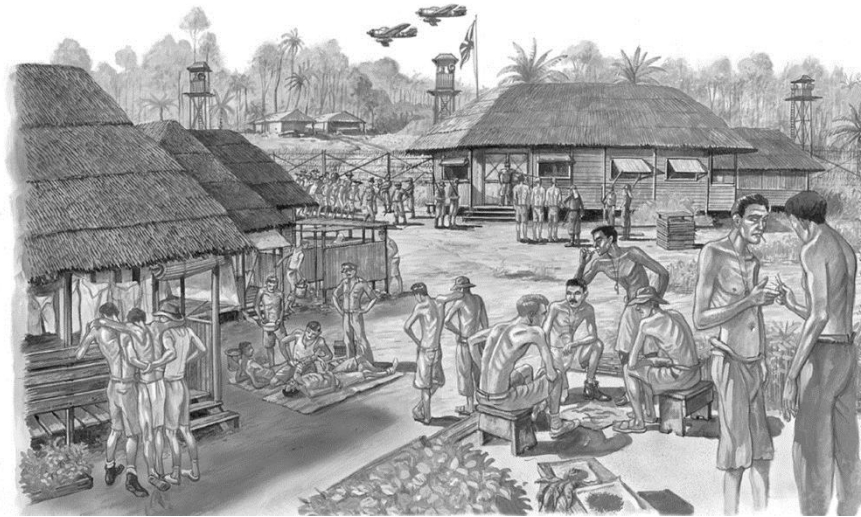
Many lives were lost in campaigns that had no effect on the outcome of the war.

HISTORY

Life as a POW

Student: Class: Due date:

Study the following illustration carefully and answer the questions below.



Artist's impression of life inside a typical jungle POW camp of the Japanese

1. What evidence is there to suggest that POWs:

- a. were underfed and malnourished? **The POWs are extremely thin — mere skin and bone.**
- b. were forced to work hard? **A group is being marched back into the compound probably from a hard day's labour; prisoners are 'cleaning' their own latrines.**
- c. had to look after their own medical needs? **Two ill or injured prisoners are lying on a mat while another bandages one's arm and a fourth has brought a bowl, probably containing water. An Officer — perhaps a doctor — looks on.**
- d. were vulnerable to tropical diseases, such as malaria? **The huts are open to the weather and there is no sign of mosquito nets. The latrines are very basic and too close to the huts; there is no sign of running water.**
- e. maintained strong ties of mateship? **While some POWs help the sick, others help a weak 'mate' to one of the huts.**

2. What aspects of prison camp life are *not* included in this illustration?

We also know that there were executions, torture and harsh punishments. Food was rationed. A Black market operated for 'luxuries' such as cigarettes.

3. How would belief in the *bushido* code affect the way Japanese soldiers treated Australian POWs?

This code would mean that Japanese soldiers would have no respect for their prisoners and thus

Would not care about their needs or comfort nor value their lives; they believed the harsh treatment

Of the POWs was deserved, not unjust.

4. On what basis might you argue against such a code? One could argue against the code on the basis

that all human life is inherently valuable.

The home front

Student: Class: Due date:

For many Australians, the war only became a real threat after the attack on Pearl Harbor and the fall of Singapore.

1. The following paragraphs describe the efforts made on the 'home front' to support troops serving overseas and to prevent a Japanese invasion of Australian territory. Fill in the gaps.

Coastwatchers

Coastwatchers were small groups of well-trained **soldiers** stationed along Australia's **coast** If they spotted **Japanese** ships entering Australian waters, they were to **monitor** the enemy's movements while remaining **undetected** The Japanese were **rarely** seen. A more prevalent enemy was **loneliness**

Volunteer Defence Corps

Some citizens feared that **public utilities** , such as water supplies and transport systems, might be **sabotaged** The **government** responded to this fear by establishing the Volunteer Defence Corps. Its job was to help keep **law** and **order** , protect public utilities and prevent '..... **subversive** ' activities. Many of the volunteers became air-raid **wardens** and taught other people what to do if enemy **bombs** fell.

Rationing

Rationing helped keep the **distribution** of goods at home steady and fair, while at the same time maintaining supplies for the **troops** Sometimes items, such as **irons** or **radios** , were so restricted people had to put their name on a **list** and wait. People learned to make do with what they had — old clothes were refashioned into **new clothes** or maidenhair ferns were used to make **tea** It came down to using your **imagination** or going without.

Slogans about spies

A campaign created to encourage people to be careful about what they **said** and what they wrote in **letters** resulted in many people becoming **suspicious** of their fellow citizens. **Internment** camps were established to separate recent **immigrants** from the rest of the population. People of **German** , **Italian** or **Japanese** descent were targeted. The Australian Communist Party was **banned**

2. Describe what it might have been like to be a child living in Australia during World War II.

Children, especially young ones, would have found it hard to understand why their soldier father or brothers were away for such a long time. They would see that their mother was worried and had to go to work — something she had never done before. She might have often come home tired.

Children might have been hungry due to the short food supply and would have had to go without 'extras', such as books, toys or birthday and Christmas presents. They might have had to put their pets down because there was no food for them.

HISTORY

War's end

Student: Class: Due date:

1. True or false? Circle T or F.

- a. In 1943, Italy surrendered. T/F
- b. In 1944, Germany failed to capture Stalingrad. T/F
- c. By 1945, Japan was defending her homeland. T/F
- d. In 1945, the Axis powers were trying to expand their territory. T/F
- e. The Allied powers planned to open a second front in Europe. T/F
- f. On 6 June 1945, an Allied invasion force landed in Normandy. T/F
- g. 6 June 1944 became known as 'D-Day'. T/F
- h. The Germans were driven back; Paris was liberated in August 1944. T/F
- i. The Allies also had success in the Netherlands. T/F
- j. The Germans were stopped in Belgium's Ardennes Forest. T/F

Europe

2. What was the Battle of the Bulge?

At the end of 1944, the Germans pushed through the usually impenetrable Ardennes Forest into Belgium, taking the US by surprise. Their maps of frontline positions showed a 'bulge' where the Germans had broken through Allied lines.

3. What did the Allies and Soviets both aim to do in 1945?

They aimed to advance on Berlin — the Allies from the west, the Soviets from the east.

4. Briefly describe the fall of Berlin and the fall of Hitler.

On 30 April 1945, the Soviets captured the German parliament buildings in Berlin and Hitler committed suicide in his bunker.

The Pacific

5. What was the US two-pronged strategy in 1943?

General MacArthur's forces advanced to the Philippines while Admiral Nimitz's forces island-hopped towards Japan, but they paid a high price in casualties and in the end did not actually invade Japan.

6. How was Japan finally defeated?

The US government decided to drop atomic bombs on the Japanese cities of Hiroshima and Nagasaki.

7. Who was the United States trying to protect by choosing this strategy?

The Allies knew that to fight Japan on her own soil would mean death and injury to many Allied soldiers, so the dropping of atomic bombs protected Allied troops.

8. Why do some historians believe this strategy was unnecessary?

Japan was already seeking ways to negotiate for peace. A simple demonstration of the power of nuclear bombs would have prompted their surrender.

9. As well as winning the war, what might have been another reason for the United States using this strategy?

Perhaps the United States wanted to show its nuclear capability to the world, especially to its post-war rival, the Soviet Union.

HISTORY

Analysing a political cartoon

Student: Class: Due date:

1. Why are political cartoons a useful source in the study of history?

Political cartoons are primary sources. Despite promoting a particular point of view, they are important as they reflected or influenced the public opinion of the time.

2. Study the cartoon below and answer the following questions.



© Corbis Australia/Clifford Kennedy Berryman

Source: Clifford K. Berryman in the *Washington Star*, 9 October 1939.

a. Who created the cartoon and who published it?

It was created by Clifford K. Berryman, published in the *Washington Star* (US newspaper).

b. When and where was it published? What is the significance of the publisher, the time and place it was published?

It was published in Washington, the US capital, in 1939 at the end of the decade that saw the rise of fascism in Europe. The *Washington Star* was probably a daily paper read by a wide public.

c. Why was it created; that is, what events or issues is it concerned with?

The US would have been concerned about expansionist nationalism in Europe, which had been a cause of the Great War. It would not want another war to take place.

d. What is its message? Consider both the image and the caption.

Its message is that Germany and the USSR are currently happy allies, but the caption raises the question of how long this contentment will last, perhaps recognising that Hitler, as groom, is dominant. (Note: The cartoon reflects the August 1939 signing of a non-aggression pact between Germany and the USSR.)

e. How does it convey this message?

The image shows Hitler and Stalin as being 'just married' and very happy, yet the caption is a cynical cliché suggesting there will be a honeymoon period before 'reality' sets in — the relationship would not last.

HISTORY

Analysing a propaganda poster

Student: Class: Due date:

Interpret the poster on the right by answering the accompanying questions.

1. Who is the intended audience?

The poster is intended for ordinary Australian citizens living in Australia.

2. What message is the poster portraying?

The message is that Japanese troops are moving south towards Australia and that it is necessary to obey rules on the home front in order to protect Australia.

3. How do you think the poster conveys this message? That is, what persuasive techniques have been used?

The large bold type of 'Always South' suggests the Japanese will not stop their march. The arrows on the map confirm the direction and breadth of Japan's advance. The prime minister's face adds authority to the request to be vigilant and helpful.

'It's total war' is bold and underlined, also emphasising the seriousness of the threat. A list of instructions clarifies what is being asked of the Australian public.

4. What is the historical context? What was happening at the time the poster was produced?

John Curtin had become prime minister in 1941. In December 1941, the Japanese had bombed Pearl Harbor and were attempting to wipe out all imperial bases in the Pacific. In early 1942, Singapore fell, and Australians were trying to hold back the Japanese on the Kokoda Trail.



5. Is there a suggestion as to what would happen if the message was:

- a. accepted? b. ignored?

Expand on your answers.

If the message of the poster was accepted, the Australian public would be more prepared for a

Japanese attack; if ignored, Australia might be vulnerable.

6. The most effective posters are those that are simple and direct — is this an effective poster? Explain your answer.

The larger elements of this poster effectively emphasise that the Japanese are a real, serious and

imminent danger. The small print at the bottom is too much text — most people would not bother to

read all the detail.

WORD SEARCH

Student: Class: Due date:

Complete the word search.



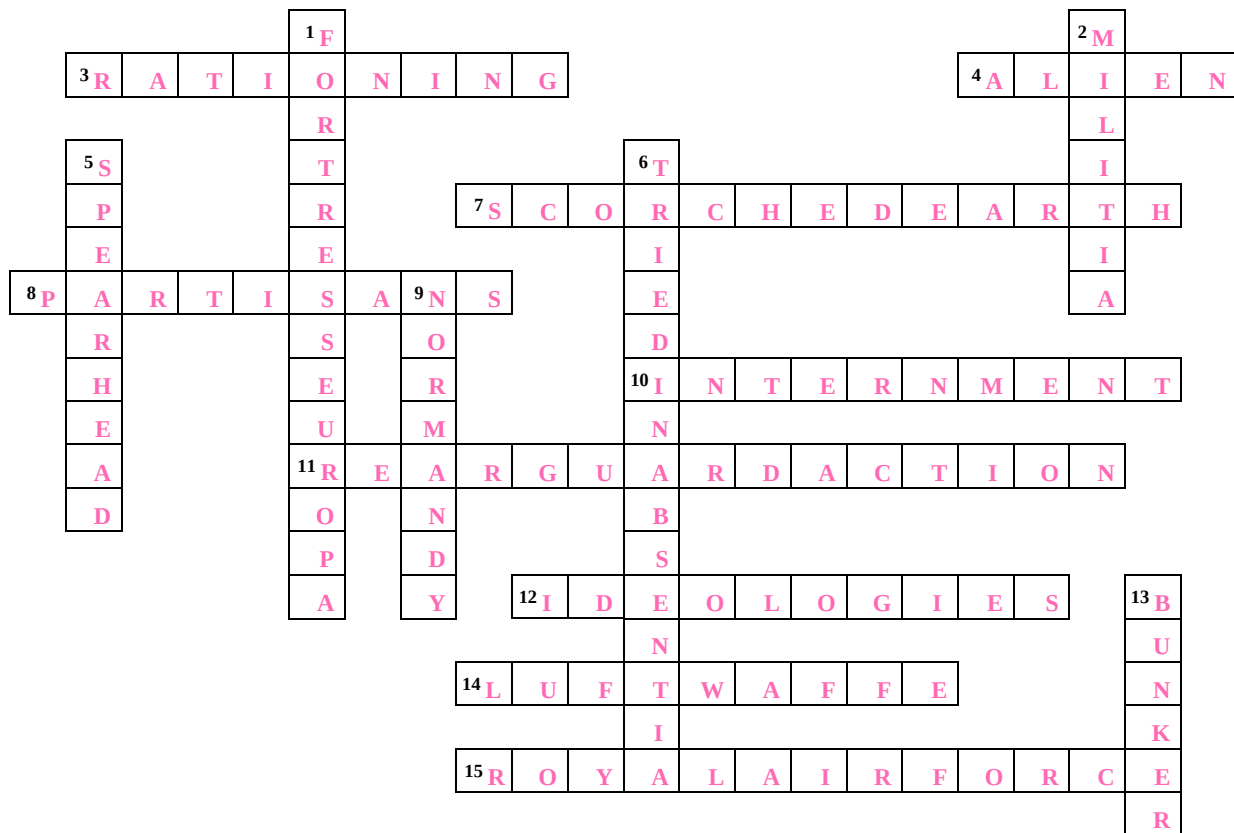
- 1 A high-speed attack using tanks
BLITZKRIEG
- 2 Leader of Russia during World War II
STALIN
- 3 Prime minister of Australia in 1939
MENZIES
- 4 Direct engagement with the enemy by troops protecting a retreating force
REARGUARD
- 5 Small groups of soldiers who guarded Australia's coastline during World War II
COASTWATCHERS
- 6 A person born in another country who is not yet a citizen of the country in which they live
ALIEN
- 7 Imprisonment for political or military reasons.....**INTERNMENT**
- 8 The German air force during World War II
LUFTWAFFE
- 9 Collective name for countries fighting against the Allies **AXIS**
- 10 Prisoner of war camp in North Borneo
SANDAKAN
- 11 Armed forces other than the official military forces **PARAMILITARY**
- 12 Irregular fighters that took a side in a war and used guerrilla tactics **PARTISANS**
- 13 The abbreviation for the Australian air force
RAAF
- 14 The abbreviation for the British air force
RAF
- 15 The abbreviation for the Australian navy
RAN
- 16 Famous battle in New Guinea
KOKODA
- 17 A policy of destruction to be used when military forces cannot repel enemy advances
SCORCHED EARTH
- 18 Ammunition and weapons
MUNITIONS
- 19 Location of US naval base Pearl Harbor
HAWAII

HISTORY

Crossword

Student: Class: Due date:

Complete the crossword.



ACROSS

- 3 Controlling the distribution of something when supplies are low (9)
- 4 A person born in another country who is not yet a citizen of the country in which they live (5)
- 7 Military strategy of destroying or removing everything that could be used by an advancing enemy (8,5)
- 8 Irregular fighters using guerrilla tactics behind enemy lines (9)
- 10 To be put in prison for political or military reasons, either real or perceived (10)
- 11 Direct engagement with the enemy by troops protecting a retreating force (9,6)
- 12 Sets of ideas or beliefs that guide an individual, group, society or nation and provide the basis of political systems (10)
- 14 The German air force during World War II (9)
- 15 Britain's Royal Air Force (5,3,5)

DOWN

- 1 The term used by Hitler to describe the defences along the coastline of Europe from Denmark to southern France (8,6)
- 2 A body of men called up for military service only in emergencies (7)
- 5 To lead an attack (9)
- 6 Tried even though the accused is not present in court (5,2,8)
- 9 A region of France on the Atlantic coast (8)
- 13 A fortified underground shelter, usually with openings from which to fire at enemies (6)